



THE BARBER OF SEVILLE

This page from the Introduction, Act I, of Rossini's most popular opera, *The Barber of Seville* (premiered in 1816), shows the composer's handwriting.

By this stage, the composer had developed many of his most familiar trademarks. He dispensed entirely with unaccompanied recitative, enabling his music to flow continuously. He noted all vocal embellishments in the score, rather than allowing his singers to improvise. Rossini himself excelled at dazzling passages of coloratura, as well as dramatic crescendos. The latter were very simple and direct, built around relentless chord progressions, although some critics found them too predictable. He also liked employing “patter-songs”—melodies that are sung at high speed for purely comic effect. These were particularly useful in sections where the narrative was flagging.

Romance and Paris